of the three battalions that made up 7 Brigade—Lieutenant Colonels Maha Singh Rikh of 2 Rajput, B. S. Ahluwalia of 1/9 Gorkha Rifles and R. N. Mishra of 9 Punjab—were all in attendance.

Even as Kaul outlined an ambitious attack plan to occupy the Thagla Ridge across the Nam Ka Chu, every officer and JCO present at the briefing knew the general's plan was nonsensical. To Dashrath's experienced ears, it sounded like the general was issuing orders for an advance the next morning across the river and up the Thagla slopes on the assumption that the Chinese did not exist. All the officers were sitting in stunned silence as Kaul droned on, using impressive jargon that included terms like 'positional warfare manoeuvre', something neither Dashrath nor any of the others present had ever heard before. Niranjan Prasad was staring at his shoes the entire time, while Dalvi meekly tried to point out a few technical difficulties like limited ammunition, lack of snow clothing, artillery support and other factors. The corps commander, deeming them minor irritants, impatiently brushed them aside.

Having spelt out his objectives, the corps commander asked the assembled officers and JCOs if they had any questions. While the officers were still recovering from the shock of Kaul's master plan, Subedar Dashrath Singh from 2 Rajput spoke up: 'Agar izaazat ho to mein kuch poochna chahta hun (If I have your permission, I would like to ask a question).'

'Haan haan, saab, pooch kya poochna hai (Yes, yes, saab, ask what you want to).'

Dashrath, who had seen five years of close combat with the Japanese in Burma and had then fought in the Jammu and Kashmir Operations in 1948, said: 'Yeh larai to maine pehli bar dekhi hai, saab, jisme hum nalle mein aur dushman upar pahar par (This is the first time I've seen a battle being planned where we are sitting in the valley while the enemy is holding the heights above us).'

'Yeh bhi pehli baar aapne dekha hoga ki koi general front line mein khara ho (This must also be the first time that you're seeing a general on the front lines),' was Kaul's glib response.

'Aapne apni baat to keh di, saab, lekin hamare jawaab nahi diya (You've said what you wanted to, sir, but you haven't answered my question),' said Dashrath. At this point Kaul lost his temper and demanded that the JCO be arrested on the spot and dismissed from service. While